

PARALLEL MINOR MODAL INTERCHANGE

Borrowing chords from C minor (or Aeolian) into C major — creating emotional contrast, darkness, and depth without changing the key center. Color category: RED.

Modal Interchange = borrowing chords from the parallel minor (same root C, but minor scale notes) and placing them inside a C major context. The key center stays C — but the borrowed chord introduces notes from C minor, creating momentary emotional darkening or contrast.

THE BIG THREE — CORE BORROWED CHORDS FROM C MINOR

BVIMA⁷ — BORROWED ♭VI

Abmaj7

in C major: A[♭] maj7

"Kiss from a Rose" — Seal

DREAMY EPIC EMOTIONAL

The most lush borrowed chord. Classic arc: ♭VI→VII-I (A[♭]-B[♭]-C). Creates a sweeping cinematic feeling. The ♭VI note (A[♭]) is the characteristic borrowed pitch — introduces the darkness of the minor scale.

IV-7 / IV-6 — BORROWED IV

Fm7/Fm6

in C major: F minor

Classic pop ballads, R&B, neo-soul

DARK RICH EXPRESSIVE

The minor iv is the most emotionally resonant borrowed chord in pop. The ♭3 of the minor chord (A[♭]) is the borrowed pitch. *Fm6 is often sweeter than Fm7* — the major 6th (D natural) softens the darkness. Note: Fm6 = D[♭]7 in 1st inversion.

II♭7 — HALF-DIM II

Dm7♭5

in C major: borrowed from C Dorian

Gospel, R&B, neo-soul

DARK YEARNING SOPHISTICATED

The half-diminished ii chord from minor (vs. the diatonic Dm7 in major). Often placed over a pedal point (bass stays on C or D while chord changes). Rich, complex subdominant function with extra darkness.

THE OTHER THREE — DARKER AND MORE SELECTIVE

BIIIIMA⁷

Ebmaj7

in C: E[♭] maj7

"Tonic Imposter" — use carefully. Creates a brief sense of a parallel major key a minor 3rd above. Sounds ambiguous. Avoid placing directly after ♭VII7 (creates confusion). Best used sparingly.

V-7 — MINOR V

Gm7

in C: G minor (vs G7)

Heavier, more grounded than G7. No leading tone urgency — creates a floating, unresolved dominant feeling. Used in heavy soul and gospel. The natural 9th (A) isn't available in the parallel minor context.

BVII7 — DUAL FUNCTION

B♭7

in C: B[♭]7 (two uses)

1. MI: B[♭]7 → C = warm resolution from below (parallel minor ♭VII). **2. Tritone Sub of E7:** B[♭]7 → Am7 is a tritone sub functioning as SubV7/vi. Understand context to determine which function is active.

THE BACKDOOR II-V — IV-7 • ♭VII7 • IMAJ7

Fm7

→

B♭7

→

Cmaj7

IV- (BORROWED)

♭VII7 (BORROWED)

IMAJ7 (HOME)

WHY IT WORKS

B[♭]7 shares the tritone F-B — same tritone as E7 (V7/vi). But the bass motion F → B → C moves by down-a-5th then up-a-step instead of down-5th-down-5th. This creates an inevitable, warm chromatic slide into home.

CHARACTER + SONG EXAMPLE

"Knocks Me Off My Feet" — Stevie Wonder. Warmer, smoother, and more emotionally rich than the standard ii-V-I. The borrowed quality (both Fm7 and B[♭]7 from parallel minor) creates consistent "borrowed" emotional temperature throughout.